

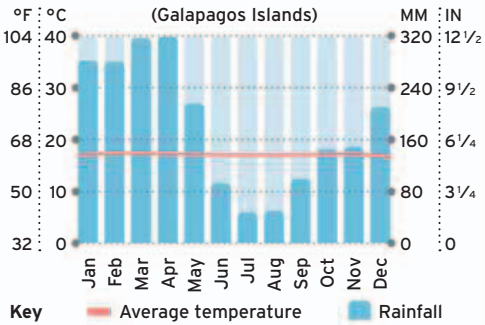
LOCATION

The Galapagos Islands lie in the Pacific Ocean, around 560 miles (900 km) due west of the coast of South America.



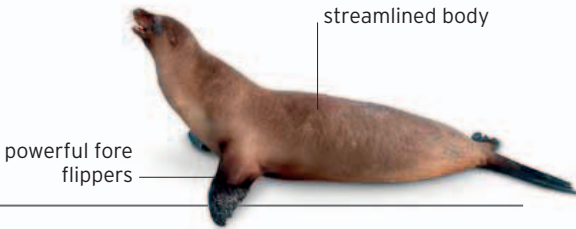
CLIMATE

The average temperature varies by a mere 1.26°F (0.7°C) throughout a year, whereas the rainfall varies drastically, especially during El Niño years.



Galapagos sea lion

Zalophus wollebaeki



Unlike its relatives, the true seals and walruses, the Galapagos sea lion is an otarid, or eared, seal. External ear flaps are one difference between otarids and true seals; another is the ability to work their hind flippers independently, which, along with stronger fore flippers, allows sea lions to move more easily on land. Like most sea lions, they can move rapidly due to their rotatable pelvis.

Colonies of curiosity

Highly social, sea lions are coastal mammals, feeding in ocean shallows before returning to the shore to sleep, rest, and nurse their young in colonies ruled by an adult male. Their inquisitive nature, particularly that of younger sea lions, brings them into contact with human activities such as fishing—often with fatal consequences. In addition, they are severely impacted by El Niño weather events: climatic changes that affect Pacific winds, ocean currents, and temperature patterns every few years, leading to a sudden depletion of fish in the area. During the El Niños of 1997–98, sea lion numbers in the Galapagos Islands fell by almost 50 percent.

↔ 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)

⚖ 110–550 lb (50–250 kg)

⊗ Endangered

🐟 Fish, squid, crustaceans

🏠

Galapagos Islands, W. South America

▽ **STRONG SWIMMERS**
Unlike true seals, which swim mainly by moving their rear flippers, sea lions use powerful, elongated front flippers to pull themselves along.



Sea lion **pups** start to develop **swimming skills** at **one to two weeks**

109 endemic species identified

COMMON ANCESTOR
Seven species of colorful lava lizard live in the Galapagos; one species occurs on several islands, but the others are found on only one island each. Like the Galapagos finches, all lava lizard species evolved from a single ancestor.

LAVA LIZARD

